given to Vice Minister Zhang. Zhou's response was that China too desired to settle all issues through discussion, adding that 'we see no difficulty in safeguarding economic and cultural interests of India in Tibet'. [23] India had more than just economic and cultural relations with Tibet; it had a political relationship since it deemed Tibet to be autonomous. With regard to the note itself, Zhou confined himself to saying that he was studying it carefully and hoped to talk about it at an early date. No specific time-frame was mentioned. In fact, the Chinese took a full four months to reply to the Indian proposals. The delay in responding was tactical. These months were used for extensive research into Tibetan archives.

The delay also allowed the Chinese to complete the military occupation of Tibet. The PLA began to move southwards along the India–Tibet border. Premier Zhou Enlai informed the Central Chinese Government's Representative in Lhasa, General Zhang Jingwu, in February 1952 that the resolution of issues with India over Tibet would have to wait for the PLA to reach the southern boundary of Tibet. When India flagged its concerns in this regard, the Chinese dismissed them as provocative reports that were the creation of imperialists (the US and the UK) who were bent on spoiling the good relations between India and China. In reality, China was using the time to prepare the grounds for the next phase of its strategy. Zhou Enlai directed General Zhang Jingwu to ensure that negotiations with India should be preceded by the establishment of a Tibet Military Committee and a Foreign Affairs Bureau fully controlled from Beijing, so that there was no reason for India to deal directly with the Tibetan government. Zhou also instructed the Chinese officials in Lhasa to conduct a detailed study of all materials in connection with India's privileges and rights in Tibet. In effect, the Chinese were engaged in doing two things in the first half of 1952 while India